Chapter 9 — Routing and Data Fetching

Real apps have many screens and live on data from a server. This chapter covers the two libraries most React apps use for that: **React Router** (which screen to show for which URL, and — in its data mode — loading the data for that screen) and **TanStack Query** (caching — keeping a reusable local copy of — and synchronising server data). It then connects both to React's own async tools, **Suspense** (shows a fallback while something is loading) and `use()` (reads a promise's value during render), and ends with patterns for loading and error states that users actually like.

You already know the manual way — fetching in an Effect with cleanup (Chapter 5, and the `useFetch` Hook in Chapter 7) — and Chapter 6 explained why server data is a different kind of state. Here you'll see what the libraries add and how to use them well.

What you'll learn

#	Topic	You will be able to…
9.1	Client-side routing	explain how an SPA changes pages without reloading
9.2	React Router v8 and its modes	install it and pick declarative, data or framework mode
9.3	Routes, links, params	map URLs to components; read `:params` and `?search` params; navigate in code; 404s
9.4	Nested routes and layouts	share layouts with `<Outlet>`, use index and pathless routes, relative links
9.5	Loaders	load data *before* a route renders; pending UI; route error boundaries
9.6	Actions and forms	handle mutations with `<Form>`, validation, redirects, `useFetcher`
9.7	Middleware, lazy routes, framework mode	guard routes, split code, know what framework mode adds
9.8	TanStack Query basics	`useQuery`, states, caching, `staleTime`/`gcTime`, dedupe, retries
9.9	Query keys, pagination, dependent queries	design keys, paginate without flicker, chain queries
9.10	Mutations and invalidation	`useMutation`, invalidate, optimistic updates with rollback
9.11	Suspense and `use()`	read promises in render, fallbacks, error boundaries, transitions
9.12	Loading and error states	choose spinners vs skeletons vs stale content; handle every failure
9.13	Putting it together	router loaders + Query cache in one small shop

Versions used: **React 19.3**, **React Router 8.4**, **TanStack Query 5.104**. Code in `code/` runs in Node with jsdom (a browser-like DOM for Node); data comes from a tiny in-memory API (a small web server that keeps its data in memory, not in a database) (`code/api-server.js`) started on `127.0.0.1` inside each script, and the `[server]` lines in the outputs are that server's log.

9.1 Client-side routing

What it is

Routing means choosing what to show based on the **URL** (the web address, e.g. `/products/3?sort=price`). In a traditional multi-page site the *server* does it: every link click requests a new HTML page and the browser reloads. In a **single-page application (SPA)** the page loads once, and a **client-side router** in JavaScript does it:

1. It intercepts clicks on its links (`<Link>`), calls `event.preventDefault()`, and updates the address bar with the **History API** (the browser's built-in functions for changing the URL and back/forward history, e.g. `history.pushState`) — no request, no reload.
2. It listens for the Back/Forward buttons (the `popstate` event).
3. It matches the new URL against your **route definitions** and renders the matching components.

Analogy: a museum with one entrance. A server-routed site sends you outside and back in through the door for every room; a client-side router just walks you down the corridor — the building (your JS, your state) stays loaded.

Why the URL matters

The URL *is* state — the most shareable state in your app. Anything a user might want to bookmark, share, refresh or go "back" to (which page, which product, which tab, filters, sort order, page number) belongs in the URL, not only in `useState`. A good router makes that easy.

Trade-offs

Client-side routing	Server routing (MPA)
Instant page changes, state survives navigation	Every page is a fresh load
Needs JS; first load downloads the app	Works without JS
The server must return `index.html` for *every* app path (so a refresh on `/products/3` doesn't 404 — the HTTP "Not Found" status)	Each URL maps to a real page
SEO (search-engine optimisation) and first paint (the first time content appears) need SSR/pre-rendering (producing HTML on the server, per request or ahead of time) for public content (Chapter 13)	Good by default

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9.2 React Router v8 and its three modes

What it is

React Router is the most widely used router for React. Version **8** (June 2026) is a deliberately small upgrade from v7: it requires React 19.2.7+ and Node 22.22+, is ESM-only (published only as modern ES modules that use `import`/`export`, not the older `require`), removes the old `react-router-dom` package, and turns v7's "future flags" (opt-in switches for upcoming behaviour) (notably **middleware**, §9.7) on by default.

```
npm install react-router          # one package; there is no react-router-dom in v8
```

```
import { Link, useParams, createBrowserRouter } from 'react-router';   // everything...
import { RouterProvider } from 'react-router/dom';                      // ...except the DOM-specific pieces
```

It can be used in three **modes** — pick one per app:

Mode	You write	Router provides	Use when
Declarative	`<BrowserRouter>` + `<Routes>`/`<Route>` JSX	URL matching, links, params, navigation	Simple SPAs, adding routing to an existing app, fetching data your own way (e.g. TanStack Query)
Data	Route **objects** passed to `createBrowserRouter`, rendered with `<RouterProvider>`	+ **loaders**, **actions**, pending states, route error boundaries (components that show a fallback when something below them throws), fetchers, middleware	SPAs that want data loading tied to navigation
Framework	Route **modules** (files) + the React Router Vite plugin	+ server rendering, code splitting per route (downloading each page's code only when needed), type generation, pre-rendering	Full-stack apps (frontend + server code together; this is the successor of the Remix framework)

Each mode includes everything in the modes above it. The sections below use **declarative** mode first (§9.3–9.4), then **data** mode (§9.5–9.7). Tests and these examples use the **memory** variants — `<MemoryRouter>` and `createMemoryRouter` — which keep the URL history in memory instead of the address bar; in a browser app you use `<BrowserRouter>` / `createBrowserRouter` with identical route definitions.

(Alternatives worth knowing: **TanStack Router**, a fully **type-safe** router (TypeScript checks your paths and params at compile time) with built-in search-param validation, and the file-based routers of **Next.js** and other frameworks.)

9.3 Routes, links and URL parameters (declarative mode)

How it works

1. Wrap the app in a router: `<BrowserRouter>` (tests: `<MemoryRouter>`).
2. Inside, `<Routes>` holds `<Route path="…" element={…}>` entries. On each URL change React Router picks the **best** matching route (it ranks routes by specificity — static **segments** (the pieces of a path between slashes) beat dynamic `:params`, which beat `*` — so the order you write them in doesn't matter).
3. **Dynamic segments** start with `:` — `/products/:productId` matches `/products/3` and `useParams()` returns `{ productId: '3' }` (always strings).
4. `path="*"` matches anything left over: your **404** page.
5. `<Link to>` navigates; **`<NavLink>`** is a Link that knows whether it's **active** (matches the current URL) and passes `isActive` to `className`/`style` (`end` makes it match exactly).
6. **Search params** (`?sort=price`) are read and written with `useSearchParams()`, which works like `useState` but stores the value in the URL.
7. **`useNavigate()`** returns a function for navigating in code (after a form submit, on a timer): `navigate('/products')`, `navigate(-1)` (back), `navigate('/login', { replace: true })` (replace the history entry). Declaratively, render `<Navigate to="/login" />`.

`code/01_declarative_routing.jsx`:

```jsx
import { MemoryRouter, Routes, Route, Link, NavLink, useParams, useSearchParams, useNavigate,
useLocation } from 'react-router';

function Nav() {
  const cls = ({ isActive }) => (isActive ? 'active' : undefined);   // NavLink knows if it matches
the URL
  return (
    <nav>
      <NavLink to="/" end className={cls}>Home</NavLink> <NavLink to="/products" className=
{cls}>Products</NavLink>
    </nav>
  );
}
function ProductList() {
  const [searchParams, setSearchParams] = useSearchParams();       // ?sort=price
  const sort = searchParams.get('sort') ?? 'name';
  const items = PRODUCTS.toSorted((a, b) => (sort === 'price' ? a.price - b.price :
a.name.localeCompare(b.name)));
  return (
    <>
      <h1>Products (by {sort})</h1>
      <button onClick={() => setSearchParams({ sort: 'price' })}>Sort by price</button>
      <ul>{items.map(p => <li key={p.id}><Link to={`/products/${p.id}`}>{p.name}</Link></li>)}</ul>
    </>
  );
}
function ProductPage() {
  const { productId } = useParams();                               // from the :productId segment
  const navigate = useNavigate();
  const product = PRODUCTS.find(p => p.id === productId);
  if (!product) return <h1>No product {productId}</h1>;
  return (
    <>
      <h1>{product.name} - ${product.price}</h1>
      <button onClick={() => navigate('/products')}>Back to list</button>
      <button onClick={() => navigate(-1)}>Browser back</button>
    </>
  );
}
function NotFound() { return <h1>404 - nothing at {useLocation().pathname}</h1>; }

function App() {
  return (
    <>
      <Nav />
      <Routes>
        <Route path="/" element={<Home />} />
        <Route path="/products" element={<ProductList />} />
        <Route path="/products/:productId" element={<ProductPage />} />
        <Route path="*" element={<NotFound />} />
      </Routes>
    </>
  );
}
// render(<MemoryRouter initialEntries={['/']}><App /></MemoryRouter>), then click around
```

Output:

```
start                   url=/                    active=Home     h1="Welcome"
click Products          url=/products            active=Products h1="Products (by name)"
sort by price           url=/products?sort=price active=Products h1="Products (by price)"
   list order: Mouse, Keyboard, Monitor
click Monitor           url=/products/3          active=Products h1="Monitor - $199"
navigate(-1)            url=/products?sort=price active=Products h1="Products (by price)"
click Mouse             url=/products/2          active=Products h1="Mouse - $19"
navigate("/products")   url=/products            active=Products h1="Products (by name)"
deep link /nope -> 404 - nothing at /nope
```

Things to notice:

- "Products" stays **active** on `/products/3` because NavLink matches descendants; "Home" uses `end` so it's active only on `/` exactly.
- The sort order lives in the URL: **Back** returned to `?sort=price`, not to the default sort. `useState` would have lost it.
- A deep link to an unknown path rendered the `*` route.

Common mistakes

Mistake	Fix
`<a href="/products">` inside the app	Full page reload, state lost — use `<Link to>` (keep `<a>` for external sites)
Treating `useParams()` values as numbers	They're strings: `Number(productId)` or compare as strings
Filters/tabs/page in `useState`	Put shareable UI state in search params
Calling `navigate()` during render	Navigate in handlers/Effects, or render `<Navigate>`
Server returns 404 on refresh of `/products/3`	Configure a fallback to `index.html` (Vite preview, Netlify `_redirects` — a hosting service's redirect file, nginx `try_files` — a web server's setting)

TL;DR

`<Routes>`/`<Route path>`; `:param` + `useParams`; `useSearchParams` for `?query`; `<Link>`/`<NavLink>`; `useNavigate` in code; `*` for 404.

9.4 Nested routes and layouts

What it is

Most apps have **layouts**: a header on every page, a sidebar on all account pages. React Router models this by **nesting** routes. A parent route renders the shared UI and an **`<Outlet />`** where the matching child route appears. The URL segments nest the same way: `users` + `:userId` = `/users/42`.

Three kinds of routes help:

Route kind	Written as	Matches	Use
Index route	`<Route index element=…>`	The parent's own URL, exactly	Default child: "Pick a user" at `/users`
Layout (pathless) route	`<Route element={<Layout/>}>` with no `path`	Nothing by itself; wraps its children	Share UI without adding a URL segment
Dynamic vs static children	`new` and `:userId` side by side	`/users/new` → static wins	Ranking, not order, decides

`code/02_nested_routes.jsx`:

```
function AppLayout() {                              // renders on EVERY page
  return (<div><header>MyShop</header><main><Outlet /></main><footer>(c) 2026</footer></div>);
}
function AccountLayout() {                          // pathless layout: groups routes, adds no URL segment
  const user = { name: 'Ada' };
  return (<section><aside>Account menu</aside><Outlet context={user} /></section>);
}
function Settings() { const user = useOutletContext(); return <h1>Settings for {user.name}</h1>; }
function UsersLayout() {
  return (
    <div>
      <nav><Link to="new">New user</Link> <Link to="42">User 42</Link> <Link to="..">Up</Link></nav>
{/* relative links */}
      <Outlet />
    </div>
  );
}

function App() {
  return (
    <Routes>
      <Route element={<AppLayout />}>                          {/* layout route: no path */}
        <Route index element={<h1>Home</h1>} />                {/* matches "/" exactly */}
        <Route path="users" element={<UsersLayout />}>
          <Route index element={<UsersIndex />} />             {/* /users */}
          <Route path="new" element={<NewUser />} />           {/* /users/new - static beats dynamic
*/}
          <Route path=":userId" element={<User />} />          {/* /users/42 */}
        </Route>
        <Route element={<AccountLayout />}>
          <Route path="settings" element={<Settings />} />
        </Route>
      </Route>
    </Routes>
  );
}
```

Output (which layout pieces are on screen, and the heading):

```
/           -> header  h1="Home"
/users      -> header+nav  h1="Pick a user"
/users/new  -> header+nav  h1="Create a user"
/users/42   -> header+nav  h1="User #42"
/settings   -> header+aside  h1="Settings for Ada"
from /users/42 click "new" -> header+nav  h1="Create a user"
click ".."              -> header  h1="Home"
```

How it works

1. React Router finds the **chain** of matching routes (e.g. `AppLayout → UsersLayout → User`).
2. It renders the outermost element; each `<Outlet />` renders the next element in the chain.
3. **Relative links** (no leading `/`) resolve against the **route** that renders them: `to="new"` inside `UsersLayout` means `/users/new`, even when the current URL is `/users/42`. `..` goes to the parent *route* — here the pathless layout at `/`.
4. `<Outlet context={value}>` + `useOutletContext()` passes data from a layout to whichever child is rendered.

Why it matters

Layouts don't re-mount when you move between their children — the header's state, the sidebar's scroll position and any open menus survive. It also mirrors how designers think: "all account pages share this sidebar".

TL;DR

Parents render `<Outlet/>`; `index` for the default child; pathless routes for shared layouts; relative links resolve against the route tree.

9.5 Loaders — data before render (data mode)

What it is

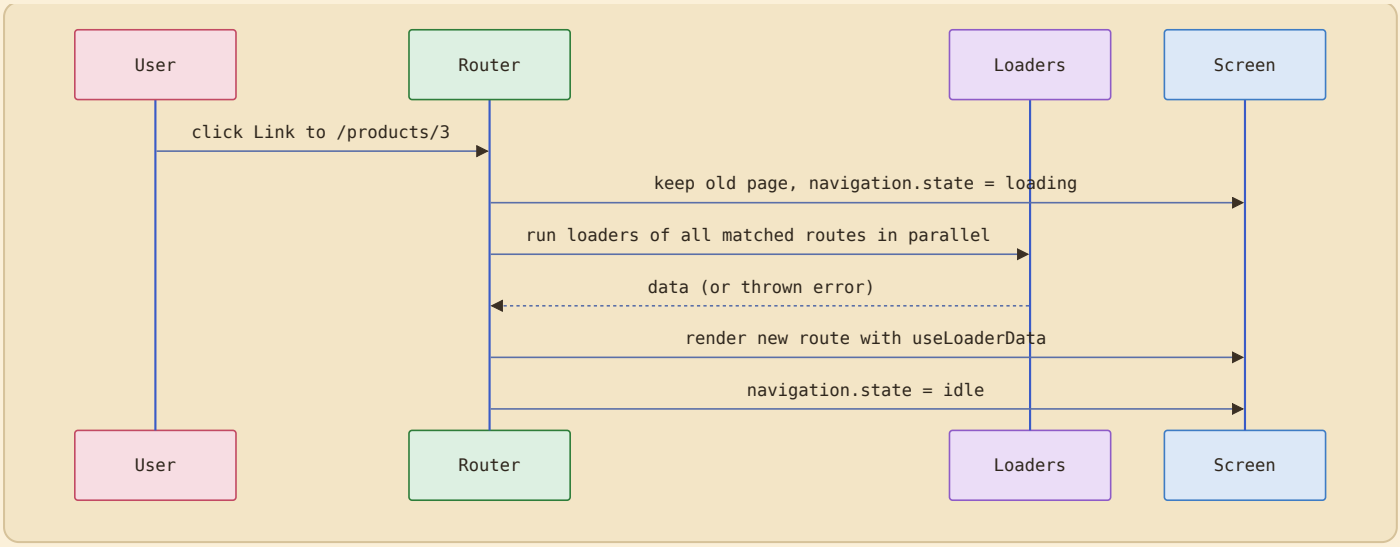
In **data mode** each route can have a `loader`: an async function that runs **when navigation to that route starts, before the route renders**. Its return value is read in the component with `useLoaderData()`.

The problem it solves

Fetching in Effects (Chapter 5) starts only *after* the component renders, and nested components each wait for their parent to render before starting their own request — a **waterfall** (request 1 → render → request 2 → render…). Loaders let the router start **all** the requests for **all** matched routes **in parallel** as soon as the user clicks — and the component renders once, with data.

How it works

1. Define routes as objects: `{ path, Component, loader, ErrorBoundary, children }`.
2. `createBrowserRouter(routes)` (tests: `createMemoryRouter(routes, { initialEntries })`) and render `<RouterProvider router={router} />`.
3. On navigation the router calls the loaders of the matched routes in parallel with `{ params, request, context }` (`request.signal` aborts if the user navigates away again).
4. While they run, the **current** screen stays visible and `useNavigation().state` is `'loading'` — use it for a progress bar.
5. When they resolve, the new route renders; `useLoaderData()` returns the data.
6. If a loader **throws**, the nearest route `ErrorBoundary` renders instead. Throw `data(message, { status })` for expected HTTP-like errors and check them with `isRouteErrorResponse(error)`.
7. On the very first load there is no "current screen", so the router shows the root route's `HydrateFallback` (what to show until the app has **hydrated** — React has started in the browser).



`code/03_loaders_and_errors.jsx`:

```
async function getJson(path, request) {
  const res = await fetch(api.base + path, { signal: request.signal });   // aborted if the user
navigates away
  if (res.status === 404) throw data((await res.json()).message, { status: 404 });
  if (!res.ok) throw new Error(`API error ${res.status}`);
  return res.json();
}

function Root() {
  const navigation = useNavigation();               // 'idle' | 'loading' | 'submitting'
  return (
    <div>
      <nav><Link to="/">All</Link> <Link to="/products/3">Monitor</Link> <Link
to="/products/9">Missing</Link></nav>
      {navigation.state === 'loading' && <p role="status">Loading…</p>}
      <Outlet />
    </div>
  );
}
function ProductList() {
  const { products, categories } = useLoaderData();
  return <h1>{products.length} products in {categories.length} categories</h1>;
}
function Product() {
  const product = useLoaderData();
  return <h1>{product.name} costs ${product.price}</h1>;
}
function ProductError() {
  const error = useRouteError();                    // whatever the loader threw
  if (isRouteErrorResponse(error)) return <h1>{error.status}: {error.data}</h1>;
  return <h1>Unexpected: {error.message}</h1>;
}

const router = createMemoryRouter([
  {
    path: '/', Component: Root, HydrateFallback: () => <p>Starting…</p>,
    children: [
      {
        index: true, Component: ProductList,
        loader: async ({ request }) => {            // two requests in PARALLEL, not a waterfall
          const [products, categories] = await Promise.all([getJson('/api/products', request),
getJson('/api/categories', request)]);
          return { products, categories };
        },
      },
      {
        path: 'products/:id', Component: Product, ErrorBoundary: ProductError,
        loader: ({ params, request }) => getJson(`/api/products/${params.id}`, request),
      },
    ],
  },
], { initialEntries: ['/'] });
render(<RouterProvider router={router} />);
```

Output:

```
first paint: Starting…
  [server] start GET /api/products
  [server] start GET /api/categories
  [server] end   GET /api/products -> 200
  [server] end   GET /api/categories -> 200
loaded     : 3 products in 2 categories
  [server] start GET /api/products/3
during nav : Loading… | still showing: 3 products in 2 categories
  [server] end   GET /api/products/3 -> 200
after nav  : Monitor costs $199
  [server] start GET /api/products/9
  [server] end   GET /api/products/9 -> 404
missing    : 404: No product 9 | nav still rendered: true
```

The server log proves the two list requests ran **in parallel**. During navigation the **old** page stayed on screen with a "Loading…" status (no blank flash). The 404 was caught by the product route's own `ErrorBoundary`, so the root layout and its nav **kept working** — errors are contained to the route that failed. (Without any `ErrorBoundary`, React Router shows a default error screen.)

Details worth knowing

- **Revalidation**: after an action (§9.6) or `useRevalidator().revalidate()`, the router re-runs the loaders on the page so data stays fresh; `shouldRevalidate` on a route can opt out.
- **Streaming non-critical data** (sending the page first and filling in slow data as it arrives): a loader can return an object containing an *un-awaited* promise (a **promise** is an object for a result that arrives later; un-awaited = not waited for) (`return { product: await p, reviews: reviewsPromise }`); render it with `<Await resolve={reviews}>` inside `<Suspense>`, or with `use()` (§9.11). The page shows as soon as the critical data is ready.
- **Loaders are not components**: no Hooks inside them. They're plain async functions, easy to **unit-test** (test in isolation).
- **Loaders don't cache**. Navigate back to a page and its loader runs again. Pair them with a cache (TanStack Query, §9.13) when that matters.

TL;DR

`loader` runs before render, in parallel for all matched routes; `useLoaderData()` reads it; `useNavigation()` for pending UI; throw `data(msg, {status})` and handle it in a route `ErrorBoundary`.

9.6 Actions, `<Form>` and fetchers

What it is

An **action** is a route's function for **writes** (create, update, delete). React Router's **`<Form method="post">`** works like an HTML form, but instead of reloading the page it **serialises** (packs into a sendable format) the fields into a `Request` (the standard object describing an HTTP request), calls the route's `action`, and then **automatically re-runs the loaders** on the page so the UI shows the new data.

How it works

1. `<Form method="post">` submits to the action of the route it's rendered in (or `action="/path"`).
2. The action reads `await request.formData()`, validates, and writes to the server.
3. It returns either:
    - **validation errors** — `return data({ errors }, { status: 400 })` — read in the component with **`useActionData()`**; or

    - **`redirect('/somewhere')`** — the classic *Post/Redirect/Get* pattern (after a form POST, send the browser to a normal GET page), so Refresh doesn't resubmit.
4. `useNavigation().state === 'submitting'` while the action runs — disable the button.
5. After the action, the router **revalidates**: loaders run again and every `useLoaderData()` gets fresh data.
6. **`useFetcher()`** does the same *without navigating* — for "like" buttons, inline edits, quick-add fields, several independent submissions at once. It has its own `fetcher.state` and `fetcher.data`.

`code/04_actions_and_forms.jsx`:

```
async function newTodoAction({ request }) {
  const form = await request.formData();              // the submitted <Form> fields
  const title = String(form.get('title') ?? '').trim();
  if (title.length < 3) return data({ errors: { title: 'At least 3 characters' } }, { status: 400 });
  await postTodo(title);
  return redirect('/todos');                          // Post/Redirect/Get
}

function TodoList() {
  const todos = useLoaderData();
  const fetcher = useFetcher();                       // submit WITHOUT navigating
  return (
    <>
      <h1>{todos.length} todos: {todos.map(t => t.title).join(', ')}</h1>
      <fetcher.Form method="post" action="/todos/new">
        <input name="title" aria-label="quick add" defaultValue="Buy milk" />
        <button>{fetcher.state === 'idle' ? 'Quick add' : 'Adding…'}</button>
      </fetcher.Form>
      <Link to="new">New todo page</Link>
    </>
  );
}
function NewTodo() {
  const actionData = useActionData();                 // what the action returned (validation errors)
  const navigation = useNavigation();
  return (
    <Form method="post">
      <h1>New todo</h1>
      <input name="title" aria-label="title" />
      {actionData?.errors?.title && <p role="alert">{actionData.errors.title}</p>}
      <button disabled={navigation.state === 'submitting'}>{navigation.state === 'submitting' ?
'Saving…' : 'Save'}</button>
    </Form>
  );
}

const router = createMemoryRouter([
  { path: '/todos', Component: Outlet, HydrateFallback: () => null, children: [
    { index: true, Component: TodoList, loader: todosLoader },
    { path: 'new', Component: NewTodo, action: newTodoAction },
  ] },
], { initialEntries: ['/todos'] });
```

Output:

```
  [server] start GET /api/todos
  [server] end   GET /api/todos -> 200
list      : 1 todos: Read chapter 9
too short : At least 3 characters | url still /todos/new
  [server] start POST /api/todos
submitting: button says "Saving…"
  [server] end   POST /api/todos -> 201
  [server] start GET /api/todos
  [server] end   GET /api/todos -> 200
redirected: /todos | 2 todos: Read chapter 9, Write the router demo
  [server] start POST /api/todos
  [server] end   POST /api/todos -> 201
  [server] start GET /api/todos
  [server] end   GET /api/todos -> 200
fetcher   : /todos | 3 todos: Read chapter 9, Write the router demo, Buy milk
```

Notice: the too-short title never reached the server; after each successful POST the router re-fetched `GET /api/todos` **by itself** — you never wrote "refresh the list" code.

Relation to React 19 form actions

React 19's own `<form action={fn}>`, `useActionState` and `useFormStatus` (Chapter 4) solve the same problem at the component level. React Router's `<Form>` adds routing concerns: URL-addressed actions, redirects and automatic revalidation of route data. In a data-mode app, prefer the router's `<Form>`/fetchers for route data.

> **TL;DR**
>
> `<Form method="post">` → route `action` → return errors (`useActionData`) or `redirect`; loaders revalidate automatically; `useFetcher` for submissions that shouldn't navigate.

9.7 Middleware, lazy routes and framework mode

Middleware (v8: on by default)

Middleware functions run **before** a route's loaders/actions, from parent to child, and can do work before and after the rest of the chain by awaiting `next()`. Typical uses: **authentication guards** (checks that send a logged-out user to the login page), logging/timing, putting shared data (the current user) into a typed **context** that loaders read.

`code/05_middleware.jsx`:

```
const userContext = createContext(null);                  // typed slot in the router context (from
react-router)

async function logMiddleware({ request }, next) {
  const path = new URL(request.url).pathname;
  console.log(`  -> ${path}`);
  await next();                                           // run the rest: child middleware + loaders
  console.log(`  <- ${path} done`);
}
async function authMiddleware({ request, context }) {
  if (!session) {
    const next = new URL(request.url).pathname;
    console.log('  auth: no session, redirecting');
    throw redirect(`/login?next=${encodeURIComponent(next)}`);
  }
  context.set(userContext, session);                      // loaders below can read it
}

const routes = [
  { path: '/', Component: Outlet, middleware: [logMiddleware], HydrateFallback: () => null, children:
[
    { path: 'login', Component: Login },
    { path: 'dashboard', Component: Dashboard, middleware: [authMiddleware],
      loader: ({ context }) => ({ user: context.get(userContext) }) },
  ] },
];
```

Output:

```
signed out, open /dashboard:
  -> /dashboard
  auth: no session, redirecting
  <- /dashboard done
  -> /login
  <- /login done
  shows "Please log in" at /login?next=%2Fdashboard
signed in, open /dashboard:
  -> /dashboard
  <- /dashboard done
  shows "Dashboard for Ada"
```

One guard on the parent protects every child route, and loaders no longer each re-check the session. (Client-side guards are about **UX** (user experience), not security — the server must still reject unauthorised API calls.) In declarative mode there is no middleware; the equivalent is a wrapper component that renders `<Navigate to="/login" replace />` when there's no user.

Lazy routes (code splitting)

Large apps shouldn't download every page up front. **Code splitting** breaks the JavaScript bundle into smaller files that load on demand. A route's `lazy` property loads its module only when the route is first visited:

```
// not run
{ path: 'reports', lazy: () => import('./routes/reports.jsx') }   // the module exports Component,
loader, …
```

React's own `lazy()` + `<Suspense>` does the same for any component (Chapter 10).

Framework mode in one page

Framework mode is React Router as a full-stack framework (the successor of Remix). Routes are declared in `app/routes.ts` and each points at a **route module** — a file that exports its pieces:

```
// app/routes.ts (not run)
import { type RouteConfig, index, route } from '@react-router/dev/routes';
export default [
  index('routes/home.tsx'),
  route('products/:id', 'routes/product.tsx'),
] satisfies RouteConfig;
```

```
// app/routes/product.tsx (not run)
import type { Route } from './+types/product';          // generated types for THIS route
export async function loader({ params }: Route.LoaderArgs) {   // runs on the server
  return { product: await db.product.find(params.id) };
}
export default function Product({ loaderData }: Route.ComponentProps) {
  return <h1>{loaderData.product.name}</h1>;             // loaderData is fully typed
}
export function ErrorBoundary({ error }: Route.ErrorBoundaryProps) { /* … */ }
```

What you get: server rendering (or `ssr: false` for an SPA, or pre-rendering to static HTML), `loader` on the server and `clientLoader` in the browser, automatic code splitting per route, and generated types so `params` and `loaderData` are type-checked. Chapter 13 compares it with Next.js.

TL;DR

Middleware = before/after hooks around loaders (auth, logging, context). `lazy` splits route code. Framework mode = route modules + SSR + typegen.

9.8 TanStack Query basics

What it is

TanStack Query (formerly React Query) is a **server-state** library: it fetches, **caches**, de-duplicates (merges identical simultaneous requests), refreshes and invalidates (marks out of date) data that lives on a server. (Caching in general: System Design Fundamentals.) You tell it *what* the data is (a **query key**) and *how* to get it (a **query function**); it handles *when*.

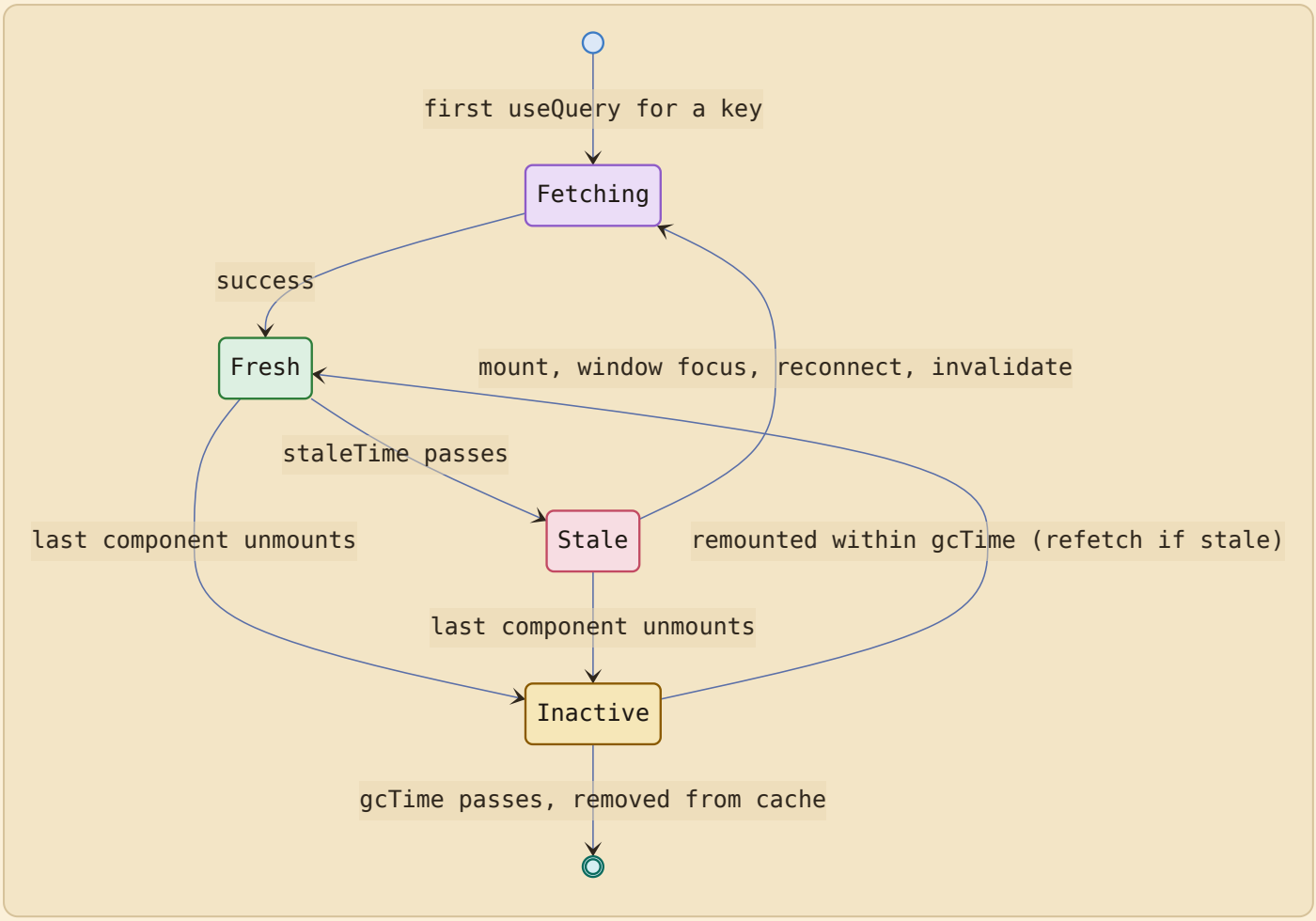
Why a special library? Server data is not like UI state (Chapter 6): someone else can change it, it can be out of date, several components need the same data, and loading/error states are everywhere. Writing that with Effects means re-implementing a cache.

How it works

1. Create one `QueryClient` (the cache) and provide it: `<QueryClientProvider client={queryClient}>`.
2. In a component: `useQuery({ queryKey: ['product', id], queryFn: () => fetchProduct(id) })`.
3. The first component to ask for a key triggers the fetch; others asking for the same key at the same time **share** it.
4. The result is stored under the key. Next time any component asks, it gets the cached data **immediately**, and — if the data is **stale** — a background refetch updates it.
5. The query function must **throw** on failure (`fetch` doesn't throw on 404 — check `res.ok`); failed queries are **retried** (3 times by default in the browser, with **exponential backoff** — waiting twice as long before each new attempt).

Two timers control the cache:

Option	Default	Meaning
`staleTime`	`0`	How long data counts as **fresh**. Fresh data is served from cache with **no** refetch. With `0`, every new mount/focus triggers a background refetch (still showing cached data instantly).
`gcTime`	5 minutes	How long **unused** data (no component using the key) stays in memory before being garbage-collected (deleted to free memory).



Stale queries are refetched automatically when a component **mounts**, when the window regains **focus**, and when the network **reconnects** (each can be turned off: `refetchOnWindowFocus: false`, …).

The states you'll use:

Field	Meaning
`status` / `isPending`, `isError`, `isSuccess`	Do we **have** data? `pending` = not yet
`fetchStatus` / `isFetching`	Is a request **in flight** right now (including background refetches)?
`isLoading`	`isPending && isFetching` — the first load
`data`, `error`, `failureCount`, `refetch()`	What you'd expect

`code/06_query_basics.jsx`:

```
function ProductName({ id, staleTime = 0 }) {
  const { data, status, fetchStatus, isPending, isFetching, error } = useQuery({
    queryKey: ['product', id],                        // cache key: identifies this data
    queryFn: () => fetchJson(`/api/products/${id}`),  // how to get it (must return a promise)
    staleTime,
  });
  timeline.push(`status=${status.padEnd(7)} fetchStatus=${fetchStatus.padEnd(8)}
isPending=${isPending} isFetching=${isFetching} data=${data?.name}`);
  if (isPending) return <p>Loading…</p>;
  if (error) return <p role="alert">Error: {error.message}</p>;
  return <p>{data.name}</p>;
}
const client = new QueryClient();
// 1) render once  2) render two at once  3) unmount + remount (staleTime 0, then 60 s)
// 4) a flaky endpoint with retry: 3   5) a 404 with retry: false

function Flaky() {
  const q = useQuery({ queryKey: ['flaky'], queryFn: () => fetchJson('/api/flaky'), retry: 3,
retryDelay: 10 });
  return <p>{q.isSuccess ? 'flaky ok' : `attempts failed so far: ${q.failureCount}`}</p>;
}
```

Output:

```
1) first load:
   status=pending fetchStatus=fetching isPending=true isFetching=true data=undefined
   status=success fetchStatus=idle     isPending=false isFetching=false data=Keyboard
2) two <ProductName id={2}/> mounted together -> requests for /api/products/2: 1
3) remount id=1 (staleTime 0): first render -> status=success fetchStatus=fetching isPending=false
isFetching=true data=Keyboard
   background refetch happened: requests for /api/products/1 = 2
   remount with staleTime 60s -> requests still 2 (fresh data, no refetch)
4) retry: 3 -> succeeded after 3 requests
5) missing product -> Error: HTTP 404
```

Reading the output:

1. The first load goes `pending/fetching` → `success/idle`.
2. **De-duplication**: two components, one request.
3. **Cache**: on remount the very first render already had `data=Keyboard` (`status=success`) while `isFetching=true` refreshed it in the background — no spinner. With `staleTime: 60s` there was no refetch at all.
4. **Retries** hid two **transient** (temporary) 503s — the HTTP "Service Unavailable" status — from the user.
5. Errors arrive as `status: 'error'` with the thrown `Error`.

Choosing `staleTime`

`0` is safe but chatty (sends many requests). For data that changes rarely (product catalogue, user profile) a `staleTime` of 30 s–5 min removes most refetches. Set a default on the client — `new QueryClient({ defaultOptions: { queries: { staleTime: 60_000 } } })` — and override per query.

Common mistakes

Mistake	Fix
Copying query data into `useState`	Use `data` directly; derive during render
Creating `new QueryClient()` inside a component	Create it once (module scope, or `useState(() => new QueryClient())`)
Query function that doesn't throw on HTTP errors	Check `res.ok` and throw
Using `isLoading` to decide whether `data` exists	Use `isPending` (or check `data`)
Turning off all refetching "because it's noisy"	Raise `staleTime` instead

In the interview

30-second answer: "TanStack Query manages server state. `useQuery` takes a key and a fetch function; it caches by key, de-dupes concurrent requests, retries failures, and refetches stale data in the background on mount, focus and reconnect. `staleTime` says how long data is fresh — default 0 — and `gcTime` how long unused data stays cached — default 5 minutes. `isPending` means no data yet; `isFetching` means a request is in flight."

- *Why not Redux for server data?* — You'd hand-write caching, dedupe, refetching and invalidation; RTK Query or TanStack Query exist because that's hard to get right.
- *What happens on window focus?* — Stale queries with mounted observers (components currently using that query) refetch.

TL;DR

`useQuery({ queryKey, queryFn })`. Cache by key, dedupe, retry, background refetch of stale data. Tune `staleTime`; `isPending` vs `isFetching`.

9.9 Query keys, pagination and dependent queries

Query keys

A **query key** is an array that uniquely identifies the data: `['products']`, `['products', 7]`, `['products', { page: 2, sort: 'price' }]`. Rules:

- **Every variable the query function uses belongs in the key.** Change a variable → new key → new cache entry → fetch. Forgetting one means the query keeps showing the old data.
- Keys are compared by value (objects are **hashed** — turned into a fixed string — with sorted keys), so `{ page: 1, sort: 'x' }` and `{ sort: 'x', page: 1 }` are the same.
- Keys are **hierarchical**: invalidating `['products']` also matches `['products', 7]` and `['products', 7, 'reviews']` — design them general → specific.

`queryOptions()` bundles a key and function into one reusable definition you can pass to `useQuery`, `useSuspenseQuery`, `prefetchQuery`, `ensureQueryData` and `getQueryData` (with TypeScript, the data type flows through).

`code/08_query_keys_pagination.jsx`:

```
const productsPage = (page) => queryOptions({
  queryKey: ['products', { page }],              // variables go IN the key -> each page cached
separately
  queryFn: () => getJson(`/api/products?page=${page}`),
});
const reviewsOf = (id) => queryOptions({ queryKey: ['products', id, 'reviews'], queryFn: () =>
getJson(`/api/products/${id}/reviews`) });

function Catalog() {
  const [page, setPage] = useState(1);
  const [selected, setSelected] = useState(null);
  const list = useQuery({ ...productsPage(page), placeholderData: keepPreviousData });  // keep old
page while next loads
  const reviews = useQuery({ ...reviewsOf(selected), enabled: selected !== null });     // waits until
something is picked
  if (list.isPending) return <p>Loading…</p>;
  return (
    <div style={{ opacity: list.isPlaceholderData ? 0.5 : 1 }}>
      <ul>{list.data.items.map(p => <li key={p.id}><button onClick={() => setSelected(p.id)}>{p.name}
</button></li>)}</ul>
      <button onClick={() => setPage(p => p - 1)} disabled={page === 1}>Prev</button>
      <button onClick={() => setPage(p => p + 1)} disabled={!list.data.hasMore ||
list.isPlaceholderData}>Next</button>
      {reviews.data && <p>Reviews: {reviews.data.join(' / ') || 'none yet'}</p>}
    </div>
  );
}
```

Output (each line is one render):

```
load page 1:
   page=1 showing=[] placeholder=false reviews=idle/pending
   page=1 showing=[Keyboard,Mouse] placeholder=false reviews=idle/pending
click Next (old page stays visible, dimmed, until page 2 arrives):
   page=2 showing=[Keyboard,Mouse] placeholder=true reviews=idle/pending
   page=2 showing=[Monitor] placeholder=false reviews=idle/pending
click Prev (page 1 is cached -> instant):
   page=1 showing=[Keyboard,Mouse] placeholder=false reviews=idle/pending
pick Mouse (the dependent reviews query is now enabled):
   page=1 showing=[Keyboard,Mouse] placeholder=false reviews=fetching/pending
   page=1 showing=[Keyboard,Mouse] placeholder=false reviews=idle/success
cache keys: ["products",{"page":1}]  ["products",null,"reviews"]  ["products",{"page":2}]
["products",2,"reviews"]
```

- **Pagination without flicker**: normally a new key means `isPending` and a spinner. `placeholderData: keepPreviousData` keeps showing page 1 (flagged `isPlaceholderData`) until page 2 arrives. Going back to page 1 was instant — it was cached.
- **Dependent queries**: `enabled: false` keeps a query idle (`fetchStatus: 'idle'`, `status: 'pending'`) until its input exists. The cache listing shows the disabled `null` entry exists but never fetched.
- For "Load more" / infinite scroll, use **`useInfiniteQuery`**, which stores pages in one cache entry and gives you `fetchNextPage` and `hasNextPage`.

TL;DR

All inputs in the key; general → specific; `queryOptions` for reuse; `keepPreviousData` for pagination; `enabled` for dependent queries; `useInfiniteQuery` for infinite lists.

9.10 Mutations, invalidation and optimistic updates

What it is

A **mutation** changes data on the server (POST/PUT/PATCH/DELETE — the HTTP methods for create, replace, partly update and delete). `useMutation({ mutationFn })` gives you `mutate(variables)` plus `isPending`, `isError`, `error`, `data`. Unlike queries, mutations don't run automatically and aren't cached by key.

After a write, the cached queries that show that data are out of date. You fix that by **invalidating** them: `queryClient.invalidateQueries({ queryKey: ['todos'] })` marks matching queries stale and refetches the ones on screen.

How it works — two strategies

Strategy	Steps	Feels	Use when
Invalidate (pessimistic — wait for the server before showing the change)	`mutate` → wait for server → invalidate → refetch → UI updates	Correct, slight delay	Default; complex server-side effects
Optimistic update	`onMutate`: cancel refetches, snapshot cache, write the expected result → server call → `onError`: restore snapshot → `onSettled`: invalidate	Instant	Likes, toggles, reordering, adding to lists — when the server almost always agrees

`code/07_mutations.jsx`:

```
function Todos({ optimistic }) {
  const queryClient = useQueryClient();
  const [title, setTitle] = useState('');
  const todos = useQuery({ queryKey: ['todos'], queryFn: getTodos });

  const mutation = useMutation({
    mutationFn: addTodo,
    // Optimistic path: show the new item immediately, remember the old list for rollback.
    onMutate: optimistic ? async (newTitle) => {
      await queryClient.cancelQueries({ queryKey: ['todos'] });          // don't let a refetch
overwrite us
      const previous = queryClient.getQueryData(['todos']);
      queryClient.setQueryData(['todos'], old => [...old, { id: 'temp', title: newTitle + ' (saving)'
}]);
      return { previous };                                                // becomes the 3rd argument
of onError
    } : undefined,
    onError: (err, newTitle, ctx) => { if (ctx?.previous) queryClient.setQueryData(['todos'],
ctx.previous); },
    onSettled: () => queryClient.invalidateQueries({ queryKey: ['todos'] }),  // refetch the truth
either way
  });

  if (todos.isPending) return <p>Loading…</p>;
  return (
    <form onSubmit={e => { e.preventDefault(); mutation.mutate(title); setTitle(''); }}>
      <ul>{todos.data.map(t => <li key={t.id}>{t.title}</li>)}</ul>
      <input aria-label="title" value={title} onChange={e => setTitle(e.target.value)} />
      <button disabled={mutation.isPending}>{mutation.isPending ? 'Adding…' : 'Add'}</button>
      {mutation.isError && <p role="alert">Could not add: {mutation.error.message}</p>}
    </form>
  );
}
```

Output:

```
  [server] start GET /api/todos
  [server] end   GET /api/todos -> 200
A) plain mutation + invalidate
   right after submit : Read chapter 9 | button: Adding…
  [server] start POST /api/todos
  [server] end   POST /api/todos -> 201
  [server] start GET /api/todos
  [server] end   GET /api/todos -> 200
   after refetch      : Read chapter 9 | Learn mutations
B) optimistic update
  [server] start GET /api/todos
  [server] start POST /api/todos
   right after submit : Read chapter 9 | Learn mutations | Ship it (saving)
  [server] end   GET /api/todos -> 200
  [server] end   POST /api/todos -> 201
  [server] start GET /api/todos
  [server] end   GET /api/todos -> 200
   after server + refetch: Read chapter 9 | Learn mutations | Ship it
C) optimistic update that fails
  [server] start POST /api/todos
   right after submit : Read chapter 9 | Learn mutations | Ship it | This will fail (saving)
  [server] end   POST /api/todos -> 500
  [server] start GET /api/todos
  [server] end   GET /api/todos -> 200
   after the 500      : Read chapter 9 | Learn mutations | Ship it | Could not add: Server refused
```

- **A**: the list updated only after the POST **and** the refetch.
- **B**: the new item appeared **immediately** (marked "saving"). The remount had started a background `GET`; `cancelQueries` made the client ignore its result so it couldn't overwrite the optimistic list. `onSettled` then replaced the temporary item with the server's version.
- **C**: the server refused; `onError` put the snapshot back, the item vanished, and the error message explains why. Always pair optimistic updates with a visible error.

Other tools

- `queryClient.setQueryData(key, data)` — write the server's response straight into the cache (skip a refetch) when the mutation returns the updated object.
- `mutateAsync` — returns a promise, for `await` in handlers (wrap in `try/catch`).
- **`useOptimistic`** (React 19, Chapter 4) gives optimistic UI for a single component's form action; TanStack's cache approach is better when many components show the same data.

TL;DR

`useMutation` for writes; `invalidateQueries` afterwards. Optimistic: cancel → snapshot → set → rollback on error → invalidate on settle.

9.11 Suspense and `use()`

What it is

`<Suspense fallback={…}>` is React's built-in way to show a placeholder while something inside it isn't ready — lazily loaded code or data. A component **suspends** when it asks for a value that isn't available yet; React shows the nearest Suspense boundary's fallback and retries the component when the value arrives.

`use(resource)` (React 19) is the API to read such a value during render:

- `use(promise)` returns the resolved value, **suspends** while pending, and **throws** the rejection to the nearest **error boundary**.
- `use(context)` reads context like `useContext`.
- Unlike Hooks, `use` **may be called inside** `if` **blocks and loops** (§7.2). It may not be called inside `try/catch`.

The one rule: don't create the promise during render

`use(fetch(url))` inside a component creates a **new** promise on every render, so React can never finish (it warns that a component "was suspended by an uncached promise"). The promise must be **created once and reused**: passed in as a prop from a Server Component (a component that runs only on the server, Chapter 13) or a loader, stored in a cache, or produced by a library (TanStack Query, the router).

`code/09_suspense_and_use.jsx`:

```
// A promise must be CREATED ONCE and reused across renders, so cache it (here: by id).
const cache = new Map();
function fetchProduct(id) {
  if (!cache.has(id)) cache.set(id, fetch(`${api.base}/api/products/${id}`).then(async r => {
    if (!r.ok) throw new Error(`HTTP ${r.status}`);
    return r.json();
  }));
  return cache.get(id);
}

const CurrencyContext = createContext('$');
function Product({ id, showPrice }) {
  const product = use(fetchProduct(id));                // suspends until resolved; throws to the boundary if rejected
  if (!showPrice) return <h2>{product.name}</h2>;
  const currency = use(CurrencyContext);                // unlike useContext, use() may sit inside an if
  return <h2>{product.name} {currency}{product.price}</h2>;
}

function Page() {
  const [id, setId] = useState(1);
  const [isPending, startTransition] = useTransition();
  return (
    <>
      <button onClick={() => setId(2)}>plain setId(2)</button>
      <button onClick={() => startTransition(() => setId(3))}>transition setId(3)</button>
      <button onClick={() => setId(9)}>missing</button>
      {isPending && <p>(switching…)</p>}
      <ErrorBoundary fallback={({ error, reset }) => <p role="alert">Failed: {error.message} <button onClick={() => { reset(); setId(1); }}>Retry</button></p>}>
        <Suspense fallback={<p>Loading product…</p>}>
          <Product id={id} showPrice />
        </Suspense>
      </ErrorBoundary>
    </>
  );
}

// The same idea with TanStack Query: useSuspenseQuery never returns "pending" - data is always defined.
function SuspenseName({ id }) {
  const { data } = useSuspenseQuery({ queryKey: ['product', id], queryFn: () => fetchProduct(id) });
  return <p>useSuspenseQuery: {data.name}</p>;
}
```

The error boundary (`code/ErrorBoundary.jsx`) is a class component (the older way of writing components as JavaScript classes) — React still has no Hook equivalent of `getDerivedStateFromError` (the class method React calls when a child throws); most apps use the small `react-error-boundary` package instead:

```
export class ErrorBoundary extends Component {
  state = { error: null };
  static getDerivedStateFromError(error) { return { error }; }       // render the fallback next
  componentDidCatch(error, info) { this.props.onError?.(error, info); } // log it (Sentry, console…)
  reset = () => this.setState({ error: null });
  render() {
    if (this.state.error) return this.props.fallback({ error: this.state.error, reset: this.reset });
    return this.props.children;
  }
}
```

Output (the visible text after each step):

```
first render      : Loading product…
resolved          : Keyboard $49
plain update      : Loading product… <- content replaced by the fallback
transition update : (switching…) Mouse $19 <- old content kept, isPending shown
then              : Monitor $199
rejected promise  : Failed: HTTP 404 Retry
after Retry       : Keyboard $49
useSuspenseQuery: Mouse
```

How it works

1. `Product` calls `use(promise)`; the promise is pending, so React stops rendering `Product` and shows the **closest** `<Suspense>` fallback.
2. When the promise settles, React re-renders `Product`; `use` now returns the value (or throws the error to the **closest error boundary**).
3. **Plain update** to an id whose data isn't loaded → the already-visible product is **hidden** and replaced by the fallback (a jarring flash).
4. **Transition update** (`startTransition`, Chapter 7) → React **keeps the old content** on screen and exposes `isPending` instead. Routers wrap navigations in transitions for exactly this reason.
5. `reset()` on the boundary clears the error and tries again (here with a different id; a real cache should also **evict** (remove) failed promises so a retry refetches).

Placing boundaries

- Put `<Suspense>` where a loading placeholder makes sense **visually** — around a card, a panel, a route — not around every component.
- Siblings inside one boundary are revealed **together** (no "popcorn" effect — pieces popping in one by one at random); separate boundaries let fast parts show first.
- Nest boundaries to stream progressively: page shell → main content → comments.
- Pair each important Suspense boundary with an **error boundary** outside it.

TL;DR

`use(promise)` + `<Suspense>` + error boundary. Cache the promise; never create it in render. Use transitions to keep old content instead of flashing fallbacks. `useSuspenseQuery` = Suspense with a cache.

9.12 Loading and error states that users like

Loading states — pick by situation

Situation	Show	Tool
First load of a page/section	**Skeleton** in the final layout (grey blocks) — avoids **layout shift** (content jumping around as things load)	Suspense fallback, `isPending`
Navigating between pages	**Old page + progress indicator** (top bar, dimming)	`useNavigation`, transitions
Refreshing data already shown	Keep data, small "refreshing" hint, or nothing	`isFetching` with data
Paginating / filtering	Previous results dimmed until new ones arrive	`keepPreviousData`, `useDeferredValue`
User action (save, like)	Disable button + inline "Saving…", or optimistic UI	`isPending` of mutation/action, `useOptimistic`
Very fast responses	**Nothing** — a spinner for 50 ms is a flicker	Delay spinners ~200–300 ms, or rely on transitions

Error states — every failure needs a home

Error kind	Where to handle	UI
Expected "not found" / 403 (HTTP "Forbidden")	Route `ErrorBoundary` via `throw data(msg, { status })`, or query `error`	A friendly page inside the layout, with navigation still working
Transient network error	Retries (Query does 3 by default), then error UI	Message + **Retry** button (`refetch()` / boundary `reset`)
Validation error on submit	Action return value / mutation error	Inline, next to the field (`role="alert"`)
Bug (exception during render)	Error boundary at route level + one at the app root	"Something went wrong" + report to monitoring (an error-tracking service such as Sentry) in `componentDidCatch`
Failure after optimistic update	`onError` rollback	Revert + toast (small temporary pop-up message) explaining what didn't save

What error boundaries **don't** catch: errors in event handlers, in async code outside render (a `setTimeout`), and in the boundary itself. Handle those with `try/catch` and state, or route them into render (e.g. `mutation.error`).

Common mistakes

- A single spinner for the whole app on every fetch — users lose context.
- Showing an error page for a failed *background* refetch while good cached data exists — show the data and a subtle warning.
- Swallowing errors (`catch {}`) so the UI stays in "Loading…" forever.
- Not handling the empty state ("No results") separately from loading and error.

TL;DR

Skeletons for first loads, old content + indicator for navigations, nothing for fast refreshes. Route/query errors in boundaries with Retry; validation errors inline; roll back optimistic updates

visibly.

9.13 Putting it together — loaders + TanStack Query

Loaders and TanStack Query solve different halves of the problem and combine well:

- The **router** knows *when* data is needed — as soon as a link is clicked — so its loaders **start** fetches early and in parallel.
- **TanStack Query** knows *whether* data is already cached and fresh, and keeps it updated afterwards.

The pattern: in the loader call `queryClient.ensureQueryData(options)` (return cached data or fetch it) for critical data, `prefetchQuery` (start, don't wait) for non-critical data, and read both in the component with the **same** `queryOptions` via `useSuspenseQuery` / `useQuery`.

`code/shop.jsx` (key parts):

```
const fresh = 30_000;                                          // treat data as fresh for 30 s
const productsQuery = queryOptions({ queryKey: ['products'], queryFn: () => getJson('/api/products'),
staleTime: fresh });
const productQuery = (id) => queryOptions({ queryKey: ['products', id], queryFn: () =>
getJson(`/api/products/${id}`), staleTime: fresh });
const reviewsQuery = (id) => queryOptions({ queryKey: ['products', id, 'reviews'], queryFn: () =>
getJson(`/api/products/${id}/reviews`), staleTime: fresh });

function Product() {
  const { id } = useParams();
  const { data: product } = useSuspenseQuery(productQuery(id));   // already in the cache thanks to
the loader
  const reviews = useQuery(reviewsQuery(id));                      // not awaited by the loader:
streams in after
  // ... render product, reviews (or "Loading reviews…")
}

return [{
  path: '/', Component: Layout, ErrorBoundary: RouteError, HydrateFallback: () => <p>Loading shop…
</p>,
  loader: () => queryClient.ensureQueryData(productsQuery),        // fetch if missing, reuse if
cached
  children: [
    { index: true, Component: Home },
    { path: 'products/:id', Component: Product, ErrorBoundary: RouteError,
      loader: async ({ params }) => {
        queryClient.prefetchQuery(reviewsQuery(params.id));          // start, but don't wait (non-
critical)
        await queryClient.ensureQueryData(productQuery(params.id));  // wait (critical)
        return null;
      } },
  ],
}];
```

`code/10_router_with_query.jsx` deep-links to `/products/1`, clicks around, then navigates to a missing product:

Output:

```
  [server] start GET /api/products
  [server] start GET /api/products/1/reviews
  [server] start GET /api/products/1
  [server] end   GET /api/products -> 200
  [server] end   GET /api/products/1/reviews -> 200
  [server] end   GET /api/products/1 -> 200
deep link /products/1 -> Keyboard | reviews: 2
  [server] start GET /api/products/3/reviews
  [server] start GET /api/products/3
  [server] end   GET /api/products/3/reviews -> 200
  [server] end   GET /api/products/3 -> 200
click Monitor         -> Monitor
back to Keyboard      -> Keyboard (served from the cache: no requests)
  [server] start GET /api/products/7/reviews
  [server] start GET /api/products/7
  [server] end   GET /api/products/7/reviews -> 200
  [server] end   GET /api/products/7 -> 404
/products/7           -> 404 - This product does not exist
```

- The deep link started **all three** requests at once (parent and child loaders run in parallel) — no waterfall.
- Returning to Keyboard made **zero** requests: loaders ran, but `ensureQueryData` found fresh cached data. Plain loaders would have refetched.
- The 404 was thrown as `data(…, { status: 404 })` from the query function and rendered by the route's `ErrorBoundary`.

In the browser (`code/shop.html`; `fetch` is mocked in `shop-main.jsx`):

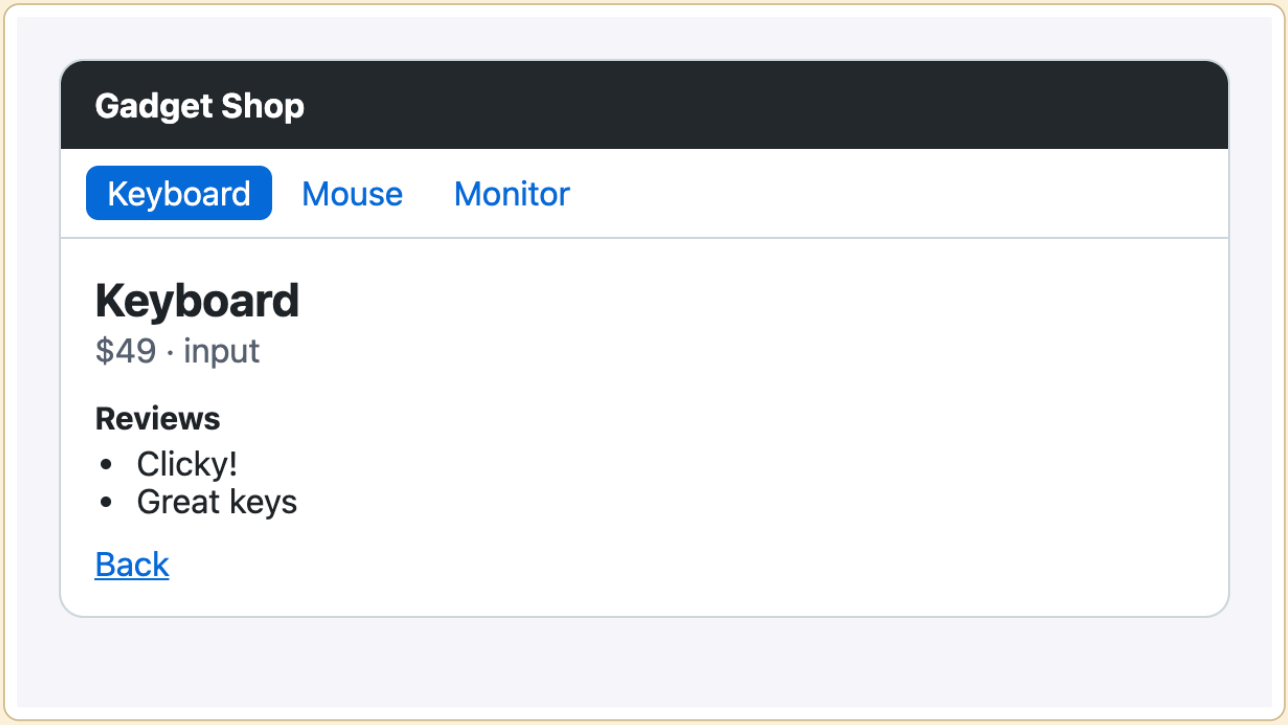


Figure 9.1 — The shop at `/products/1`. `NavLink` highlighted the active product; the product came from the loader-filled cache, the reviews from a prefetch.

In the interview

30-second answer: "I'd use React Router's data mode so loaders start fetching as soon as navigation begins, in parallel, and TanStack Query as the cache: the loader calls `ensureQueryData` with shared `queryOptions`, the component reads the same options with `useSuspenseQuery`. Critical data is awaited, non-critical data is prefetched and shown when

> ready. Mutations go through actions or `useMutation` and invalidate the affected keys. Errors are handled by route error boundaries, and navigations are transitions so the old page stays visible."

- *Why both a router loader and a query?* — The loader removes the render-then-fetch waterfall; the query cache removes repeated requests and keeps data fresh.
- *Where would you put the `QueryClient`?* — Created once outside components, provided at the root, and passed to route loaders.

Chapter 9 TL;DR

Idea	Remember
Client-side routing	History API + route matching; URL is shareable state
React Router v8	`npm i react-router`; `RouterProvider` from `react-router/dom`; declarative / data / framework modes
Routes	`path`, `:params` (`useParams`), `?search` (`useSearchParams`), `*` 404, `<Link>`/`<NavLink>`, `useNavigate`
Nesting	`<Outlet/>`, `index`, pathless layouts, relative links, `useOutletContext`
Loaders	Run before render, in parallel; `useLoaderData`; `useNavigation` for pending; `throw data(msg,{status})` + `ErrorBoundary`
Actions	`<Form method="post">` → `action` → errors (`useActionData`) or `redirect`; automatic revalidation; `useFetcher`
Middleware	Before/after loaders; auth guards; `createContext` + `context.get/set`
TanStack Query	Key + fn; cache, dedupe, retries, background refetch; `staleTime` (0) / `gcTime` (5 min); `isPending` vs `isFetching`
Keys & pagination	Every input in the key; `queryOptions`; `keepPreviousData`; `enabled`; `useInfiniteQuery`
Mutations	`useMutation` + `invalidateQueries`; optimistic: cancel → snapshot → set → rollback → invalidate
Suspense & `use()`	Cached promise only; fallback while pending; error boundary for rejections; transitions keep old UI
Loading/error UX	Skeletons first, old content during navigation, inline validation, Retry buttons, visible rollbacks

Next: Chapter 10 — Performance.